



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 50

WEST VIRGINIA

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside West Virginia's family courts and child-welfare system.

32

WEST VIRGINIA FAMILIES ON RECORD
· 49 CHILDREN IMPACTED · 7 MONTHS
MEDIAN TIME IN SYSTEM

REPORT GENERATED
APRIL 24, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED
10 OF 55

COMPILED BY
MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

WEST VIRGINIA AT A GLANCE.

Across 32 West Virginia families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 49 32 of 32 families reporting with kids	MEDIAN ATTORNEY FEES \$0 per reporting family	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 7 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 50.0% 28.1% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 32	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 1.5	REPORTING FAMILIES 32 of 32	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 10

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so West Virginia families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02 THE COST OF WEST VIRGINIA FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

Expense Category	Responses	Median	Mean	Total Reported
Attorney Fees	32	\$0	\$13,125	\$420,000
Lost Wages	32	\$0	\$4,853	\$155,300
Other Court Fees	32	\$0	\$188	\$6,000
Therapy / Evaluations	32	\$0	\$1,488	\$47,600
Reunification Services	32	\$0	\$500	\$16,000
GAL Fees	32	\$0	\$1,494	\$47,800
Asset Loss ¹	32	\$0	—	—
Estimated Median Family Impact	—	\$0	—	—

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median (\$0) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

Metric	Value	Unit
Median months lost	7	0.6 yrs
Mean months lost	29	2.4 yrs
Total across all families	830	69.2 yrs

03 WHO IS REPORTING · WEST VIRGINIA

Most families documenting in West Virginia are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Currently involved / "S...		13	41%
Unknown		7	22%
Case closed (more tha...		6	19%
Case closed (within th...		4	12%
I was a Child of Family...		1	3%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and ...		15	47%
CPS (Child Protective ...		9	28%
Family Court Only		5	16%
Unknown		3	9%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years		9	28%
5 – 10 years		7	22%
Less than 6 months		4	12%
3 – 5 years		4	12%
3-5 years		2	6%

CUSTODY STATUS

No Contact / Total Los...		9	28%
Adopted Out (Rights Te...		8	25%
Visitation Only		8	25%
Children in Foster Care		4	12%
Full Custody		2	6%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Unknown		7	22%
Barbour county		3	9%
Mason		3	9%
Harrison		2	6%
Wood		2	6%
Roane		2	6%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

False Accusations CPS...		11	34%
Family Court False Ac...		10	31%
Other: (Short answer)		4	12%
No due process starts ...		2	6%
Foster Care / Terminat...		1	3%

05 PARENT VOICES — WEST VIRGINIA

Quotes appear as submitted. Long submissions are trimmed with [...] to fit the page; the full unedited quote is available in the online version of this report.



They've absolutely uprooted and destroyed my family because of them my oldest son doesn't know who I am and is adopted out to some random strangers whom I am pursuing is probably the prosecuting attorney on the case because she said she wanted him in the beginning of the case [...]

— SABRINA

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

They have broken a good family up over ones false statements and no due process or let the parents evidence into court didn't want anything positive from the parents and said terrible untrue things about the parents in court the gal had only seen the two younger kids once in a [...]

— WEST VIRGINIA PARENT · ANONYMOUS

MORE VOICES FROM WEST VIRGINIA

The system sealed and silenced us while stripping all of us of our rights and innocence, not just the children.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Destroyed my entire family. My now adult children have problems from enduring this trauma. My marriage failed because of this. I lost custody of my youngest 2 children to my ex husband, with the assistance of him paying off CPS workers to take my children with no investigation [...]

— AMANDA

Traumatized us my children have been medically neglected and abused since being in state care

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Cps has done nothing but tear my family apart for years. I have severe PTSD and anxiety so badly. My children do too. My youngest child now suffers from an eating disorder. I just want her back home. I will never stop fighting for her.

— CONNIE

Separated and divided the family and alienated me from my kids

— DANIEL

The system has completely DESTROYED my family. I feel like I have no purpose to live anymore.

— AMBER

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



*DESTROYED CHILDRENS CHILDHOOD, 13 FOSTER HOMES, AND SEPARATED
Boys. DEEPLY HURT WHOLE FAMILY, WE WILL NEVER LOOK AT FAMILY COURT THE
SAME THEY ARE SAVAGES!*

— GAIL

Lied put whatever in reports cussed me n kids n gets by with it

— TAMMY

Ripped my identity of being a MOTHER and turned me into a ghost to my children when I'm all they ever known.! Separated all my children breaking our soul tied bonds.! Took a piece a paper of lies to erase DNA !.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Has literally taken my very life

— RACHEL

They have taken my Heart, my soul, my love, my life and stomped it into hell on earth.

— T

There was no investigation, only an initial contact with CPS alleging educational neglect, in regards to missing 3rd grade assessment. I explained this was our 3rd grade year and assessment is due by June 30 2026. Heard nothing else from CPS. 3.5 months later sheriff serves me [...]

— MISTI

Ruined my life health spirit. I am dead inside

— DANIELLE

They have not only stolen my sense of self but they've robbed me and my husband of creating a bond with our newborn. They have shattered my daughters (6 yr old) trust and emotional health.

— CHELSEA

They put my son through unnecessary stress

— TRACEY

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Tire me and my son apart after we've had a rough year due to his dad's accidentally shooting himself in front of our son, then losing my dad 2 months later, more they pull him from the one who always raised him causing more trauma

— MISTI

The system has destroyed my family. They couldn't care less about my daughter. They knew I was unable to fork out all the money I needed to to get proper legal representation.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Ruined my life not only my kids but mine after my mom was killed 25 years ago by my stepdad

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They have traumatized us, villainized us, and caused us an extreme amount of emotional and mental anguish, while putting me over \$40,000 in credit debt. Took away my precious parenting time and my daughters teen years that we will never get back.

— HEATHER

Broken our home, our hearts, our trust in the system. Taken precious time that I will never get back with my child.

— NICOLE

It completely tore my world apart and made me have no hope in the justice system/government!

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Basically, murdered me!

— RACHEL

The court system that says God as our witnesses allowed a criminal lawyer defend criminals in family court. The psychological harm and reputation is forever dipped in hell and I'll gladly give up my ticket to upstairs to meet them at its gate in the Gods Court

— KAYLA

25 West Virginia parents submitted ranked quotes. 25 appear in this report; the remainder are available at standwithmeg.com/wv.

06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this West Virginia report comes from West Virginia respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in West Virginia — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 32 West Virginia families reporting here are not the universe of West Virginia families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – April 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics (email + name + submission date) are applied before aggregation. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte–Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*.

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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